

HIGH RISK
Delhi's Sarojini Nagar market on Dec. 28

ANI

MT per day of oxygen. The government has also cleared anti-viral drug Molnupiravir for use. In a clinical trial of high-risk people during the early course of illness, the drug was shown to reduce hospitalisation and deaths by around 30 per cent. It will be manufactured by 13 companies in India.

Data on Omicron cases in India showed only 30 per cent to be symptomatic—mostly similar to that of common cold. "People are likely to confuse Omicron infection with common cold. The disease caused by Omicron is quite different from Delta. So far, it is milder," says Rakesh Mishra, director, Tata Institute for Genetics and Society, Bengaluru, and former chief of the Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology at the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR).

India's daily testing has fallen since September, and ranged between 886,263 and 1.25 million in the first week of December, as per ICMR (Indian Council of Medical Research). Kerala, with a positivity rate of 7.7 per cent—the highest in the country—had conducted only 42,149 tests on December 26. "Covid treatment and prevention depends heavily on timely diagnosis. Many of the medicines have to be given in the first few days after symptoms set in. It is difficult to ascertain the full spread and pin down upon emerging hotspots if people do not come forward for testing," says Dr Pandit.

A major challenge on the horizon is the assembly elections scheduled in early 2022 in UP, Punjab, Uttarakhand, Goa and Manipur. On December 23, health secretary Rajesh Bhushan asked all poll-bound states to ramp up vaccination. The MoHFW has sent multidisciplinary teams to UP and Punjab over these states reporting vaccinations below the national average. In UP, 83 per cent of the eligible population has received the first dose and 46 per cent are fully vaccinated. Punjab has administered 26 million doses; 77 per cent of the eligible population has received the first dose and 41 per cent are fully vaccinated. "We have seen how breaking Covid protection rules can lead to sudden surges. Those mistakes shouldn't be repeated," says public health expert K. Srinath Reddy. While vaccines, new treatment options and ramped up Covid infrastructure have placed us in a stronger position against Omicron than during the Delta wave, complacency can prove costly. ■

